

Hidden tech

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The future of e-commerce

We chat with Jeremy King who has led product, engineering, and web ops teams charged with developing Walmart's online business on a global scale as the company moves to the next generation of e-commerce

◀ **Jeremy King, Senior Vice President and Chief Technology Officer of Global e-Commerce at Walmart**

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Q Assuming that Walmart is going to bring in retail stores to India sometime in the future, in what way will the website start off? We've already seen Best Price, Walmart's wholesale presence here, will it be similar?

Jeremy: We don't have any plans now to enter the Indian market. We have 10 major websites that are integrated in the various forms around the world. The major businesses are pretty well integrated digitally. So, grocery for example, in the UK is connected directly to the digital experience. If you can order online and schedule a delivery, do returns and pick ups too. Walmart has around 10,000 stores across the world. 60% of America live within 5 miles of a Walmart and our secret to success is making sure our digital presence connects very seamlessly with your shopping experience whether it's at home you want deliveries or you're going to pick groceries three times a week.

As we build out capabilities in Bangalore, we're looking at investment in the supply chain. It's incredibly complex, I'll just take the US for example, effectively we have 30-50 distribution centers that you can ship from but then you have

5000 different distribution centers that you can get goods from. So it's a difficult math problem, and as you invest in the supply chain, we're looking for people like data scientists who can deal with these problems.

Q Globally is there a shift you've noticed in consumer behaviour between physically going to a Walmart vis-a-vis ordering online? Are you planning on expanding on the online presence in which case?

Jeremy: When I started four years ago, effectively the Walmart.com website - I'm generalising here a little - was only selling items online and helping to prepare for your shopping trip at the store. So effectively your online items were almost the same that you had in the store items. Since we have been onboard, we've expanded the assortment by 700%, so went from million items four years ago to 7 million items and we'll be expanding that to many more millions this year and beyond. So, the growth of the assortment is a key part of this, and you know I tell people sometimes the key task - is effectively to take that box (the store is often called the big box store) and to move the back wall because the back of the store is a very small sort of back room that you import your items and push it out to the store.

What we want to do is to have the showroom stock a lot less quantity of items but a lot more variety in items and then allow the digital experience to say "I want a different colour of that shirt, it's not in the store right now but I'm going to happen to be here anyway tomorrow so I'll just ship it to the store and pick it up." You can see a local assortment being captured together in a network of stores.

So, absolutely I think the customer expects that as well, they don't care whether it's online, mobile team or store's team, they all want it to work. I want to return an item online, I'll better be able to return the item in the store and there's nothing more annoying than that to deal with that kind of stuff. So these are the Omni-channel digital physical integration capabilities that we're dealing with. At Walmart we are talking about massive scale. I love the way the Apple Store works and the integration that they have done. It's great to have a thousand items in the store, but with Walmart we are talking 200,000 in a super center and seven million of them online that you want to integrate the stuff, it's a scale challenge. The complexity of the scale is enormous. We have 200 million customers walking into Walmart every week. These kind of scale numbers are almost hard to believe.